

Despair in the Pandora's Box

Yat

The development of a schizoid personality

Hope can never be;
in a frosted heart.
Fate rules the world?
No love can face.
Age does remove wee,
of a sadder soul.
Yet anguish never withers;
time has no power.
So does wisdom decay,
in a short day.

- Yat

'The thirst of Tantalus - the client and his sufferings'

Joseph is a successful, outstanding college student of twenty with an asthenic constitution, somewhat between ectomorphy and mesomorphy. His life is quite a legend; he is the kind of man who, after you have been acquainted with him, somehow makes you feel that he is, in some ways, juvenile and whimsical. In fact, he has a young face and always smiles to his acquaintances. In action, he is aggressive and ostentatious, but is capable of behaving inconspicuously. But when you know him better, you will probably be aware of the complexities of his thoughts. I have known him for years and it is not long when he came to me, complaining that his self cannot grow and he is dead psychologically. Since we are good friends, I promised that I can act as an 'amateur' psychiatrist and help him to solve his problems. When we were in Form Two, he started to speak about his family. He fell in 'love' with a girl in Form Three but was rejected by her in Lower Six, though he continued to woo her until the beginning of Upper Six. He also frequently reports to me that he loathes his family and constantly rejects his parents.

The following is the clinical biography of my client:

The parents of Joseph are not rich or happy people. They had been married three years before he was born. They had a daughter before him but she died after birth. His father did not want to have any child then but his mother insisted on having a child before they practised birth control. And Joseph was born and reared as the only child of the family. Despite his mother had to work outside in daytime because of economic circumstances, he developed a strong emotional attachment to her. He was left to his grandmother for caring; nevertheless, his mother would frequently bring back toys to please him in the evening. Joseph feels that he was much loved in his childhood. At the age of four, he attended a kindergarten in which he cried a lot. The teachers and

almas tried to coax him with toys and all kinds of everything. Eventually, they succeeded in calming him down. However, they all went away the next day and were substituted by a new group of teachers. He cried and refused to go back. The whole episode lasted only four days. Then, his family moved to Hong Kong Island and he studied in another kindergarten. He was reported to be a shy, solitary and withdrawn child. He even did not have the courage to ask to go to toilet. As a result, the ground of the kindergarten was covered with his urine. After graduation, Joseph enrolled in a primary school nearby in which he could attain academic excellence in his study. These years, he said, were probably the happiest years with his mother for she really indulged in him by buying toys and playthings and conforming to his wishes. They always went to see movies and had lunch outside. Joseph can remember that his mother would tell him to cover his eyes when they saw any sexual performance in the films they watched. Moreover, he said that his mother always took him out with a man whom he called Uncle and had lunch and excursions together. The man was supposed to be his mother's intimate friend and he nearly came with a big car every Saturday. Joseph held that he was quite happy with them but was a little bit surprised that there seemed to be less interactions between his father and mother. The grandmother of Joseph died when he was in Primary Two and his family was reported to have quarrel with that of the real uncle (his mother's brother). They broke off eventually. After that, his mother continued to communicate with her 'intimate friend' until 1967. That year, riots occurred in Hong Kong and the family of Uncle immigrated to Taiwan. Though Joseph frequently had sickness and accidents during his childhood, he passed through it without any noticeable emotional turbulence.

On the whole, these years were his happy days. Only several incidents had amazed him: when he was punished by his class-master in Primary Two, he suddenly cried convulsively and the teacher had to release him; Joseph reported that he was just acting on that occasion and felt strange and terrible about himself. Other cases included biting the arm of a strong boy in which he was rebuked by the drawing teacher as a dog before the class and cheating in the marking of examination papers. Another incident that made him very anxious was his ability to erect. Joseph can remember vividly how he had an erection on a bus: he had to put his hands in the pockets of the trousers in order to 'hold and hide' it. Besides, he expressed hostility and impatience towards his parents at times, but did not know why. Notwithstanding, he was highly dependent on his mother who seemed to dominate all aspects of his life. He could vaguely sense the conflict and pathology inside his family; the myths his parents shared and expected.

After taking the Secondary School Entrance Examination, he was admitted to an 'aristocratic' secondary school in which he was taught by a brutal sadistic teacher. In his own words, 'I was the first student in the academic year to be slapped and hit by my tiger form master; but I only reversed some items in my address! He then called me an ass and an idiot.....' At that time, I was one of his classmate and I knew that he was very unhappy and miserable. The tiger form master called him the Lunatic and did always slapped him and scolded him before the class. Of course, other students, including me, had received numerous insults and slaps too. He joined the Scouts that year but was not trusted by his patrol leader - he even remarked that Joseph behaved like a thief before the patrol. It was quite unfortunate that Joseph could not derive much security from the school. One of his classmates always attacked him, kicked him and called him the Lunatic. Several boys in Form Two threatened to beat him up. Gradually, he could perceive the pathological interactions within his family. He said that he could never identify with his father. In fact, his paternal image has never been strong. Instead, he clung to his mother. She, he felt, was a very dominant, vain and selfish woman. She always blamed her husband for his low salary and slight prestige, belittling him as a worthless log. Secretly, she told her son that she did not love her husband. She then would start complaining how awkward and useless his father was and how great and altruistic she was. 'If not for you,' she told her son, 'I will immediately get a divorce; so you should be obedient and helpful.' When his parents quarrelled, Joseph remarked, they would use him as a shield and force him to take side, so that when he helped either side, the other would scold him. In the process, he said, he was torn between them. His mother always warned him that he should never resemble his father for he was the most asinine log in the world. If she had a chance, she would not have married this worthless log. On the other hand, his father would sometimes tell him that she should cut off relation with Uncle and that she was vile. Originally, he was sympathetic with his father and would help him when he was scolded by his wife. Yet, gradually, he found that his father was in fact very passive, docile and awkward. He had no will power and ambition, speak less of self-determination, all together. Finally, in Joseph's eyes, his father was and is a meek ass at best. His mother then made the conditions even more ambiguous and contradictory by attributing every mistake Joseph committed, or every incident that she considered to be wrong, to be the hereditary traits of his father. These attributes made him anxious, angry and guilty. However, he began to excel himself in both his academic results and extra-curricular activities. He became devoted to a girl through whom he

could have, at least, some ideals to strive for.

When the grandmother of Joseph died, his father spoke to him about questions of life and death and asked him to join the Sunday School. He received a Christian education and became a would-be Protestant. Joseph can recall that when he was in Form Two, he became identified with a Sunday School teacher, who taught him many branches of knowledge, even psychoanalysis! His faith was quite strong at that time: he would lead the prayers for his family and rely on God for decisions. Yet, masturbation made him feel guilty and remorseful. Joseph did not stay as a Christian and he left his Church after Form Five. He also withdrew from the mawkish familial interactions. It was too painful for him to participate. His infatuation with the girl, as far as I know, was maudlin and unhealthy. Devoid of any confidence and experience in interpersonal relations he simply engaged himself in autistic thinking, hoping that the girl would love and support him. Finally, the girl rejected him, though he continued to woo her. Thus, the girl did everything to hurt his self-esteem by saying that he was weak, meek and childish. It did not only enhance his original derivative complex of pathological familial interactions, but also his sense of worthlessness and futility. His emotional self was convinced that he was nobody and withdrew further to his inner world.

Frankly speaking, at the end of Lower Six, Joseph was perilously close to psychotic development. It was too painful to face his reality. Luckily, he could channel his feelings into extra-curricular activities, especially from Form Four to Upper Six, and had gained much prestige in them. After matriculation, he entered a post-secondary school and seemed to resume part of his confidence. He frequently complained that he had very bad feelings. In April this year, he started to report his dreams to me. He also said that he is infatuated with an unacquainted feminine girl now!

'Despair in the Pandora's Box - analysis and discussion'

Clinically, Joseph is a schizoid, perhaps quite mild now. From the earlier account of his life, we can see that he could never be himself - he was attached to his mother, who influenced him indirectly through the arousal of his vehement guilt feeling. This can be reflected from his reluctance and resistance to divulge his familial and personal situations. In fact, he was warned by his parents from his childhood that he should never reveal personal and familial conditions, lest others would hurt him or their love would be withdrawn from him as a result of such knowledge. Besides, he was urged to obey his mother for she was 'all-good' and 'all-benevolent'. In this way, she

could control his actions and in fact, possess him by this seal of guilt feeling. The pathological familial interactions and the disparagement of his father made him question his identity as the son of his parents. There were both positive and negative identification with his father - he disgusted the passivity and awkwardness of his father but inevitably caught in it; his mother told him directly that he should never resemble his worthless father but indirectly pointed out that he was just a replica of him. The affect field of his mother was very strong and these forms of ambiguity and arbitrariness rendered him anxious. His father, on the other hand, was very secretive and detached, remaining aloof from any deep emotional participation. Many friends looked down upon them for the low income and social position of his family. And Joseph remarked that once he had to stand up before two hundred guests in a wedding feast and rebuke them as bastards because his whole family was disgraced by some old friends and his mother cried in the feast. Regarding with the prestige and status of his family, his mother was at all very vain about them. She would always urge her husband to 'climb the social ladder' and to earn more for the family. Yet, his father did not even care to listen. There had been several excellent opportunities to change his job but he did not initiate any attempt. In fact, he was passively indifferent towards these chances. Joseph reported that his mother was quite fashionable and dressed to the extent that her friends would regard her as the wife of a well-to-do man. She would somewhat lie to them about her husband's salary and the economic conditions of the family.

His father was very aloof from the participation of the interactions inside the family. He sometimes behaved as if his wife and his son were not with him. He seldom talked or expressed feelings though he would try desperately to influence them at times. Joseph said that his father would set up some myths inside the family and made them believe in them by instilling phobias and paranoid thoughts. The world was a perpetual threat to them: everywhere was filled with danger and his father would then have a chance to control them. Tragically, many characteristics of his familial system had been internalized when he was still a child - any betrayal of such internalized attitudes, emotions and percepts would provoke his guilt feeling and his anxiety. At secondary school, his feelings of himself were becoming more and more crystallized. He was taught a brutal teacher who could only debase him as a worthless mass of cells and hurt his self-esteem substantially. Besides, he was not trusted - all these compelled him to withdraw from interpersonal processes and to assume masks and roles in virtually all human relations. Masturbation, occasional revolt against his family, Christianity and his identification with his father

all served to intensify his sense of worthlessness and futility. He then developed a pathological devotion to a girl, who, in his imagination, could love him and support him. Engaged in his autistic thinking, he was the director, the playwright, the actor and the actress combined. In imagination, he was free, free from the maudlin and disgusting family; free from the tyranny of his environment. Yet, in reality, he became more and more futile and meaningless. No real satisfaction came; but only illusory content. His self, in his own words, is differentiated into several selves - a rational self, an emotional self and a hierarchy of false selves, each of which is further divided into different levels and all these are essentially conflicting. This process can be reflected in his dream: he wanted to dismount a taxi near his house. He saw that the pavement was packed with corpses but still insisted on getting off. However, the driver did not consent and drove the taxi away. When the driver stopped and looked back with fright, he discovered that the driver was himself! Another dream was that he watched the dissection of a man who died extremely horribly and somehow identified the man with him. Again, real actions confirmed his scission of his self - when he talked about his personal experience, he exhibited no emotional involvement. He just said that it was his rational self talking, but not his emotional self. Another example is his ambivalence towards an unacquainted feminine girl - the 'ultimate' level of his emotional self pines for love and intimacy from her; another level says that she would reject him; one level thinks that he himself is worthless and unworthy as her lover; still another holds that fate governs love and that love is infantile, while his rational self tells him to keep cool. Thus, he frowns at the girl and does not know how to do. His past experience has probably set a limitation to his present behaviour. The client also said that he virtually has no difficulty in dealing with ordinary people for he can utilize his false-self system to comply to their wishes and emotions. Yet, he fails all together when he is confronted with the girl he needs. He explained this by saying that this is a temporary regression to his infantile stage. Joseph always gets very 'bad' feelings - he feels that he is a very senile rover, in shabbiness and rags, possessing nothing and never will go back to the place he has been. Moreover, he hopes that he can meet new people every day and nobody will ever discover him. Yet, he cherishes the thought that he can have a rebirth through love and that the girl he is infatuated with will one day discover him and 'dig him out', actualizing his potential and making him alive, real and substantial. But, at times, he will feel that all his thinking is desperate and autistic - the girl, for sure, will reject this worthless, useless mass of cells. Joseph also reported that he is frequently caught in his affect states, in which he experiences vehement anxiety, feeling that all his cells

go 'sour' and that his visceral and thoraxical organs decay. During this state, he has to calm down himself by embracing his pillow or stroking his thorax and abdomen.

Withdrawal from familial interactions is a very painful process for Joseph - he has come to a stalemate and has to reject his parents continuously in his personal affairs. He cuts off their advice, shuts down their intervention and even laughs terribly after hurting them with sarcasm and rebuff. Notwithstanding, the whole process makes him guilty and anxious. This can be seen clearly in his dream: a priest was performing baptism to a vampire (female) and he was seen transformed into a vampire; then, the priest stepped down the stage and walked towards him, but with the face of a woman, and asked him to go away with his friend. Besides, the frequent associations of ghosts with his mother in his dreams hinted at the fear and rejection of his domineering mother. His deep hostility and resentment towards her are expressed openly - every time when she tries to influence his views and decisions or even to know his thoughts and feelings, he will get terribly angry and revulsive. The same procedure applies to his father also. Joseph said that he cannot stand having them intrude into his life. He simply loathes their characters and personalities. His actions and thoughts depart radically from them. Yet, he cannot resolve his problem - he is quite hostile to aggressive women but inevitably attracted to them. His father cannot fulfil his masculine role adequately in the family: the consequence is the unconscious confusion of sexual roles of Joseph, he felt that he was but a belonging of his mother; he had no identity of himself. There was no paternal identification, but only maternal identification. As he grew up, he began to assert his masculine role and his identity but was prevented by the associated derivative complex of pathological familial interactions. He sought to escape such situations by detaching his self from participation in the family processes and later, in the interpersonal processes, thus becoming a schizoid.

The platonic devotion to a girl from Form Three to Upper Six helped him pass several critical stages in these years, otherwise, he said, he would probably be a delinquent or a psychotic. When he was rejected by the girl, his conditions deteriorated severely. He remembered that at that time, he just felt that his inner self died and that he had no place in this world again. He reported that he was nearly catatonic for several weeks. He described this feeling in the following way: 'Now in the weird, obdurate phantasy I dwell, all silent and dead - only absolute darkness reigns. Not even a trace of solacing light can spring; nor senses of direction, nor flowing of streams. Neither there are resplendent starry nights; no laughter, no delight. No familiar shapes, no

living creatures. My earnest quest, my fervour, my life - all rupture; all fallen, to the tempest of desperation! All melt. For what? Nothingness but nothingness is mine; nor even hope in the Pandora's Box! Nor space, nor time. Only boisterous whirlwind blows.....' Perhaps Joseph is right, nothing can be more distressing than this intentional but inevitable project of self-annihilation; he has opened the Pandora's Box, all the evils and sufferings escape into his world; and only despair pervades. I hope that he can transcend his conditions through the efforts of himself and others. Let us bless him.